

In the open source world, a lot of people are looking at this aspect. Red Hat specifically has a security response team that looks for holes. We know certain classes of bugs that cause security issues and buffer overflows. Our security response team investigates codes and actively finds solutions for problems. If you are a subscriber to Red Hat and you've got some issues with our solution, we will push a fix right to you. You don't even have to think about it. We always make sure that you are up to date.

Closed source vendors don't want their users to know about any bugs in their solution. You could be vulnerable in that case. Whereas, with open source, there is no such thing as the vulnerability is not disclosed. Loopholes sometimes emerge but we make sure that we can get those fixes pushed out from our side.

Ploski: We have an excellent record for our response to bug fixes. Across all the airlines, telcos, healthcare companies, commercial banks and US executive departments, open source is legitimate. Moreover, open source tends to have a much faster response rate on the bug patch front compared to proprietary, closed source solutions.

Q The Indian government has recently adopted an open source policy. What's your take on this move?

McWhirter: This initiative is certainly good and highly fruitful not just for the public sector, which will benefit from the new decision, but is also beneficial to the open source community as a whole. The US government and 40 nations around the world have also started supporting open source in their operations. This represents a preference for those who develop open source solutions. Such developments will ultimately save tax payers' and the government's money, in the long term.

Q What is the most important factor driving people to choose open source?

McWhirter: The most important factor that underscores the need for an open source solution is when you realise that you have a voice. If you are buying from a closed source company, you can make suggestions to its forum or through email, but no one is going to consider your suggestions in their entirety, in their next release. Companies developing closed source solutions have their own roadmap, and they can't construct their design based on your suggestions. Although we also work on some roadmaps, we are influenced by our customers and the community. So even if you haven't paid us any money but started using our product, we are on IRC and have a public email address to receive your feedback. You can reach us and directly affect our products, just by using your voice.

An open source solution can address the primary cause of your problems, whereas a closed solution offers you 'a

least worst solution' for the same problems. Open source lets you make your voice heard among the public by simply being Internet active. Furthermore, the chances are quite high that you can make the software better by just giving your feedback.

Ploski: In the case of traditional software, you might not be able to get a free solution. You can try and opt for a freemium solution. But open source makes things better by allowing you to share your words. Overall, it's not just one factor but a combination of ownership and citizenship that directs you towards an open source solution rather than a closed one.

McWhirter: The community behind a product plays a big role in its success, in the open source world. It's an important and more accurate means of connecting you with like-minded people. If I have no one using my software, why am I even creating it? I need suggestions and feedback from the community to improve my presence in the world of software.

Q Why should developers focus on open source?

Ploski: It's simple. Open source allows you as a developer to see if it is your bug or my bug. This means that I can debug anything, step by step. It gives you full clarity when finding solutions to issues.

McWhirter: To make it easy for you to fix bugs that exist in your solution, the source augments the documentation. If I get into the source, I can resolve the issues right from the root and improve the experience. I can find out whether it's really a bug or just some misunderstanding.

As a developer, everything that will make my career successful is related to open source. You can advance your own career by being an expert for open source and create new solutions for open source. If I work in the closed source space, producing just closed source solutions, all I have to show for my work is my resume. But if I am contributing to open source, I can point to some of my repositories on GitHub and say I did this or I contributed to that.

Open source gives you proof of what you can do. In the US, many organisations have already started asking candidates to share the link to their GitHub account. It's becoming a trend, which could reach new heights in the coming future.

Q Is it a myth that Java will soon vanish from the software market? How is Red Hat ensuring the future of Java?

McWhirter: If you read some tech blogs or community posts on Facebook and LinkedIn, everyone is proclaiming the death of Java. I am quite sure that Java isn't going anywhere and is here to stay. It's still growing and getting bigger. People have been predicting Java's death for the last